



**SNAPSHOTS OF A DISPUTE**
(Clockwise from top left) Muslims protest the Gyanvapi survey; Shringar Gauri priest Jitendra Nath Vyas shows some old documents; Sohan Lal Arya, a petitioner's husband; police stand guard during the survey





PTI

was witness to the discovery of the *linga*-like structure. "As AIM's lawyer, I was inside Gyanvapi when the structure was found. I can safely tell you that it is a fountain, not a *linga*."

The advocate goes on to add that he also finds odd the May 17 Supreme Court order that allows Muslims to offer *namaaz* at Gyanvapi while securing the *shivalinga* that was found. "If you cordon off that area, you stop people from using the *wazookhana*. How can a Muslim offer *namaaz* without performing *wazoo*? Also, isn't it strange how we can now 'allow' people to offer *namaaz* at a place of worship that is very much theirs?"

While Vyas and her fellow plaintiffs had started by asking similar questions about Ma Shringar Gauri, there are some in Banaras who, in turn, doubt the fervour of their piety. Especially as the Vyas family, as distinct from Manju Vyas, are priests at the temples of Nandi, Ganesh, Gaurishankar, Tarakeswar Mahadev and Lord Hanuman, and also caretakers of the Shringar Gauri shrine. Jitendra Nath Vyas, who oversees worship at the shrine, says, "Shringar Gauri is seen daily but she is worshipped only once a year—on the Chaturthi of Vasantik Chaitra Navratri. This tradition has always been going on. Shringar Gauri is not worshipped regularly and this demand is not justified."

In 1991, when the Ram temple movement was reaching its peak in Ayodhya, the dispute related to Kashi Vishwanath and Gyanvapi mosque also reached the court in Varanasi. After the demolition of the Babri Masjid in 1992, security at Gyanvapi was tightened, and the entire complex barricaded. Mahant Surendra Tiwari of the Kalika temple says, "In 1996, Hindu and Muslim festivals fell on the same day. The road leading to Shringar Gauri was closed for security. After that, it was closed forever."

Following the inauguration of work on the Kashi Vishwanath Corridor in 2021, a path was created in the western part of the Gyanvapi complex which made the shrine of Shringar Gauri quite accessible. Indu Prakash Srivastava, the Vyas family's lawyer, says, "Devotees of Shringar Gauri are getting regular *darshan* now, but